SECTION 1 · CASE 3

Robbing the Rich

Robin Hood and six centuries of retelling · England, 1370s to today

Robin Hood is first mentioned in the 1370s, when the poem *Piers Plowman* refers to ‘rhymes of Robin Hood’. The poem says nothing about who he was or what he did; it tells us only that such rhymes already circulated.

The earliest surviving ballads, from about 1450, describe an outlaw living in the forest with a band of followers, in conflict with a corrupt sheriff. He stops wealthy travellers on the road and takes what they carry at the point of a weapon. The ballads are frank about the violence, and they are also frank about what they do not say: they do not describe him giving to the poor. That line is first set down plainly by John Stow in 1592, roughly a century after *A Gest of Robyn Hode*, and it is the version that has lasted.

Owner, loss and law are all present. The travellers owned what they carried, they lost it, and Robin lived outside the law’s protection as a declared outlaw. Nothing is missing. What changed was not the robbery but the story told about it afterwards — and each retelling gave the robberies a better reason.

OWNER ✓ LOSS ✓ LAW ✓ → **Thief, retold as hero**